AI FOR MANAGERS · STUDY GUIDE

How to Build the Team Working Standard – Layer 2

How should our recurring work happen with AI in it?

MODULE 3 · LESSON 4 | ALIGN: BUILDING A SHARED WAY OF WORKING | Action lesson · 10–12 min

THE CORE IDEA

The five agreements set shared expectations. The workflow descriptions give recurring work a shared shape. Together they form the Team Working Standard.

Make the current process visible first – then change it only where it doesn't meet the team's agreements.

1 Clear agreement, five interpretations

Take your review agreement: client-facing AI-assisted work needs human review. Clear – but hand it to five people and you get five interpretations: different things checked, at different moments, different ideas of who owns the final call. A **workflow description** closes that gap: one repeatable reference for how the work actually runs – what gets reviewed, when, and by whom – mostly by making how the work already runs explicit.

2 What counts as a workflow

Every team runs on the same logic: something comes in, work happens, something goes out. A workflow is one recurring sequence of that kind – identifiable steps, a clear input, a defined output. Its description answers: what starts the task, where AI enters, what information it uses, what it produces, where human judgment or verification occurs, and who remains accountable. Describe **what people do, not which tool they use** – the description stays accurate when the tool changes.

3 Do you need workflow descriptions at all?

Two questions decide. **Do multiple people do the same task? Is the output high-stakes** – going to a client, informing a decision, carrying real risk? If neither, the five agreements are enough for now. If at least one is yes, describe **two or three workflows** – not all: the ones where AI is already in the work and the stakes are highest.

4 The four-step workflow method

Step 1 – Select the workflow

The strongest candidates: AI is already involved, and the output matters. Ask which two or three tasks have changed most since AI arrived; pick one and anchor it in a recent, specific example.

Step 2 – Draw the current process

Map the task start to finish: what starts it, what happens next, where AI is already involved, what happens before the output is shared. One line, step by step, is enough – mark AI steps, judgment, verification.

Step 3 – Run one Five Agreements check

Once, across the completed map: **Tools** (which tool, where) · **Data** (what enters it) · **Review** (where judgment and verification occur) · **Disclosure** (when involvement must be visible, to whom) · **Direction and Support**

(what value AI adds, which capabilities the work still needs, what support people need). Add whatever the check shows is missing.

Step 4 – Finalize the process flow

Update the map with what was agreed; mark AI steps, human judgment, verification, decisions, and ownership; confirm it with the people who do the work. **The finalized flow is the workflow description.**

Two special cases: an **agentic tool** – AI taking a broader goal through several steps before you see a result – needs added lines for what it can access, what it must not do, and where a person reviews before the output moves on. Pending tool approval: map what the team may currently use and mark proposed AI steps as pending.

5 Draft it with AI, check it with the team

You don't have to write it up yourself: paste your notes and finalized flow into an approved AI tool for the clean written version – then check it against what was decided and correct anything wrong. Share the draft while the discussion is fresh, for one round of input: anything wrong, missing, or unclear? A check, not a vote – the manager remains accountable for the final standard.

With the checked workflow descriptions added to the five agreements, the **Team Working Standard is complete** – Layer 1 and Layer 2, one document. Complete is not yet active; that is the next lesson's job.

WHAT TO DO DIFFERENTLY AFTER THIS LESSON

- Start where AI is already in the work and the output matters – **two or three workflows**, never all.
- Make the current process visible **before** deciding whether it changes – documenting a sound practice is a valid outcome.
- Run the Five Agreements check once, across the whole map – not five checks per step.
- Let AI draft the write-up, but check it against the decisions before it circulates.

Module 3 · Align: Building a Shared Way of Working – this module turns the picture from Assess into one shared Team Working Standard. Download with this lesson: Handout C – Workflow Template. **Next: Lesson 3.5 – Putting the Team Working Standard into Practice** – making the completed standard active, and keeping it that way.